

We thank you for your time spent taking this survey.
Your response has been recorded.

Informatics Ethics Application Form

Please note that you can only work on one application at a time.

The "Save and Continue" option uses cookies to store the current progress of your application, so in order to return to a form, you must be using the same browser.

In addition, you cannot go back and correct mistakes you made in earlier parts of the form after the survey has branched. If you notice a mistake in your form, please email **ethics-query@inf.ed.ac.uk** with your reference number **239589** and we will assess your application based on the correction.

All of these shortcomings will be addressed in a new, University-wide system for ethics applications. Until this system is in place, this is the preferred form.

Project title

Investigating Financial Content on YouTube: Identifying Trends, NLP Analysis and Automated Detection of Misleading Financial Claims

Principal Investigator name and affiliation (for students/visiting researchers: this is your supervisor)

Dr. T.J.Elmas

Principal Investigator email

tugrulcan@ed.ac.uk

Additional non-student investigators

Email of additional non-student investigators (separate emails with commas)

Project type (tick all that apply)

- ☐ Undergraduate/MInf final year project
- ☒ **MSc final year project**
- ☐ Study conducted as part of a PhD
- ☐ Study conducted as part of research visit/internship
- ☐ Grant-funded research
- ☐ Unfunded research
- ☐ Seeking initial ethical approval as part of a grant proposal
- ☐ Other

Students involved (list names AND student IDs, using their official Edinburgh student ID, e.g. Abel Student s1234567. Separate multiple students with commas).

Is there a sponsor or a funding body?

- ☒ **No**
- ☐ Yes, their name(s) is/are:

What is the relevant code of conduct for your research?

☒ **School of Informatics Code of Conduct**

☐ Other

Are other institutions and/or Ethics Committees involved?

☒ **No**

☐ Yes, their name(s) is/are:

Level 0 Check

These questions help determine whether you need to submit a complete Level 1 or Level 2 ethics application, and whether the School of Informatics is the appropriate institution to grant ethical approval.

We cannot process studies that involve collecting data from live animals (the only exception being *Homo sapiens sapiens*), but members of the wider ethics panel can help you with applying for such approval from the appropriate sources.

Does your work involve human participants?

☒ **Yes**

☐ No

Does your work involve animals?

☐ Yes, and we will collect new data from animals

☐ Yes, but only secondary data

☒ **No**

Does your work involve military applications?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Does your work involve personal data? This includes, for example, names, student numbers, social media usernames, IP addresses, or any other data from which an individual can be identified. For more information, please consult the [**ICO web page**](#).

☒ **Yes**

☐ No

Does your work involve sensitive personal data? This includes information about physical and mental health, race, ethnicity, political opinions, religious beliefs, trade union membership, sexual orientation, genetic data, or biometric data. For more information, please consult the [ICO web page](#).

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Does your work involve developing countries? ([List of ODA recipients](#). Note that India also counts as a developing country).

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Does your research concern terrorist or extremist groups, or groups that are regarded as terrorist or extremist in the countries where they operate?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

You need **Level 1** or **Level 2 Approval**.

Please prepare a study plan, a participant information sheet, a plan for collecting consent, and a plan for managing the data collected in your study before you work through the rest of the application. Templates for all of these can be found on the [**Informatics Hub**](#).

Please also ensure that you consult our [**frequently asked questions \(FAQs\)**](#) if anything is unclear.

If you don't have your documents ready, we recommend that you save the form at this point and return to it once you've prepared the necessary information.

About Your Research

Much of the work in Informatics is iterative. This can mean different versions of studies that follow the same pattern, a set of experiments that are part of a bigger study, or the iterative development of a product.

We encourage you, if you can, to submit an ethics application that covers all of your work, and phrase your participant information sheet (PIS) and consent forms accordingly. It is also possible to submit multiple information sheets and consent forms at the same time.

Example 1: Student Kim Doe makes a spaced repetition app. They want to test several versions of the app with participants. Kim should write a generic PIS that covers several iterations, and submit it – this will cover the entire project.

Example 2: Dr Sandy Doe wants to run a perception experiment, but first needs to collect and validate stimuli. If Sandy provides sufficient documentation for the validation step and for the actual experiment, both can be approved in one go.

Please provide a brief summary of the goal and methods of your research. You should cover the following:

- What is the goal of the study?
- If you have human participants, what will you ask them to do?
- If you perform data analyses, what methods will you use?
- To what extent will the design of later parts of your study be affected by the findings of earlier parts?

It's enough to give high-level descriptions of tasks and analysis methods. It helps if you can provide references.

Recommended length: 100 words. Required length: at least 200 characters.

Financial content on YouTube has proliferated into a largely unregulated ecosystem of money-making advice, yet no systematic computational study has mapped it or distinguished legitimate guidance from misleading claims at scale. This project addresses both gaps using the YouNiverse dataset, extended to 2026 via the YouTube Data API. Phase one applies FASTopic to construct a cross-strategy taxonomy of hustlesphere content and trace strategy lifecycle trajectories. Phase two develops an NLP classifier combining gradient-boosted and transformer-based models, trained on a purpose-built labelled dataset of 800-1,000 videos annotated against externally validated criteria. Outputs include the first unified hustlesphere taxonomy, a reusable labelled dataset, and a proof-of-concept classifier targeting a Macro F1 of 0.65 to 0.72, with direct applications to platform governance and regulatory monitoring.

Are you using secondary data (e.g. social media data, corpora, datasets from repositories)?

☒ **Yes**

☐ No

Are you collecting data about identifiable individuals without their explicit consent (e.g. from social media or online forums)?

☐ Yes

☒ **Yes, but only from public figures and/or from pages accessible to the general public**

☐ No

Are you working with partners that are not from the School of Informatics? Tick all that apply.

☒ **No**

☐ Yes, academic partners

☐ Yes, non-academic partners

Who will directly benefit from your research?

Direct benefits include compensation for participation that is used to advertise the study (e.g. money, the chance to win Amazon vouchers, free pizza).

Think about academic partners, non-academic partners, participants, participants' local communities, and other potential beneficiaries (recommended length: 50 words).

Academics behind the research.

Permissions for research outside of the UK (tick all that apply)

- All research will take place within the UK. This also covers**
- ☒ **crowdsourced research where all the participants are from the UK/resident in the UK.**
 - ☐ Some research will take place in other countries, and we will obtain in-country ethical approval before starting work there.
 - ☐ Some research will take place in other countries where it is not possible to obtain in-country ethical approval. This covers crowdsourced research where not all participants are from the UK.

Working with Human Participants

This section applies to you if your research involves working with people or actively observing people (e.g. ethnography).

Note that you need consent so that you can collect data ethically from participants. However, consent is no longer the legal basis for processing data – this is Article 6(1)(e), the public task of the University.

Consent can be withdrawn – the University's public task remains.

Are all participants aged 15 and over?

- ☒ **Yes**
- ☐ No, but we will seek consent from both children and parents/guardians for those who are under age.
- ☐ No, and we will not seek consent from parents/guardians.

Are all participants able to understand their rights and provide informed consent to data collection?

- ☒ **Yes**
- ☐ No

Will you recruit participants through organisations that require specific permissions, such as schools or the NHS (both patients and NHS employees)?

- ☐ Yes, and we have already secured permission.
- ☐ Yes, but we still need to secure approval and permission.
- ☒ **No**

How do you ensure confidentiality? Describe your procedures for anonymisation/pseudonymisation, ensuring participants cannot be reidentified, and other relevant procedures. Recommended length: 50 words.

All data within the YouNiverse dataset is anonymised beyond that which the YouTube API automatically anonymises data – so the YouNiverse has an extra layer of anonymity and the YouTube API is anonymised by YouTube itself to protect its users' privacy.

How do you obtain informed consent? This also involves telling your participants about your obligations under General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). Tick all that apply.

- ☐ Participants will complete a paper consent form.
- ☐ Participants will consent using an electronic form.
- ☐ Participants will provide verbal consent. Please explain why this is necessary and sufficient.

- ☐ No need for informed consent; we will observe people as part of an ethnographic study.

☒ **Other (please explain)**

People already consented to this data becoming available via the YouTube privacy T&C's where it says it may be used for academic purposes, by signing up to YouTube users had to give consent in order to join the platform.

Will you deceive participants as part of your research (e.g. Wizard of Oz study)?

☒ **No**

- ☐ Yes, and they will be debriefed at the end of the study (please say how).

- ☐ Yes, and they will not be debriefed at the end of the study (please explain why).

Is there clear potential for significant psychological harm or stress for anyone who is involved in the research (including the researchers themselves)?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Is there clear potential for significant physical harm or discomfort for anyone who is involved in the research (including the researchers themselves)?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Is there clear potential that you will violate the social or cultural norms or practices of anyone who is involved in the research (including the researchers themselves)?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Is there clear potential for negative consequences, conflict, or other discomfort for those people on whom your research will impact?

☐ Yes

☒ **No**

Do you have a moral responsibility to provide feedback or results to research participants (e.g. administering validated diagnostic tests)?

☒ **No**

☐ Yes, but none of the research team is professionally qualified to interpret the results and communicate them to participants.

☐ Yes, and a member of the research team is professionally qualified to interpret the results and communicate them to participants.

Will you disseminate your findings to the study participants?

☐ Yes, we will directly disseminate to participants or organisations.

☐ Yes, publications resulting from our work will be made available via Pure or another public website.

☒ **No, findings will be in a project report that may not be published.**

☐ No (explain why)

Secondary Data Analysis

This includes corpora, image repositories, social media platforms, and other archives, repositories, and data sources.

Do you require access to data repositories or archives?

- ☐ No
- ☐ Yes, and I will need ethical approval before I can arrange access.
- ☒ **Yes, I already have access.**

We confirm that the intended handling, processing, and usage of the data will adhere to the terms and conditions of the source (e.g. researcher, agency, archive, social media platform).

- ☒ **Yes**
- ☐ No

This assessment is required for all studies that involve data. Before you answer these questions, make sure that you have a data management plan that minimises the transfer of data outside of the UK, EU, and EEA, and that you have completed basic training in data protection that is available via **People and Money for staff** and **Learn Ultra for research students**.

Further details available [here](#).

The questions are based on the standard University template. They will be difficult to interpret unless you have done the training – the wording is a compromise between being understandable and fitting in with the legal requirements.

As a reminder:

- The legal basis for all academic research using personal data is Article 6(1)(e) – the public task of the University.
- The legal basis for using special categories of personal data is Article 9(2)(j) – that processing is necessary for research purposes.

If you collect or use NHS data, please refer to the [ACCORD website](#) for further information. You are highly likely to need special permissions (e.g. Caldicott Guardian approval).

Research data can be stored indefinitely as long as it is stored securely – more information can be found on the [Research](#)

[Data Service website](#).

Please give the reasons why your research is in the public interest. Tick all that apply.

☒ **Public interest will be confirmed by the School of Informatics Ethics Committee.**

☐ Research Ethics Committee approval (not involving School of Informatics Ethics Committee).

☐ Confidentiality Advisory Group (CAG) recommendation for support in England and Wales.

☐ Favourable opinion from Public Benefit and Privacy Panel for Health and Social Care in Scotland.

☐ Other (please explain)

We confirm that all researchers from the University of Edinburgh have completed data protection training. Learn more about this training and how to access the mandatory modules as a member of staff (People and Money) or as a research student (Learn Ultra) on the [University's web pages on data protection](#).

☒ **Yes**

☐ No

How have you trained all researchers who have access to the data on their responsibilities for safe data handling and storage? Listing training programmes and certificates is sufficient.

Modules via the Edinburgh University (Learn Ultra) courses in the Universities web pages on data protection.

Will you collect or use NHS data?

- ☒ **No**
- ☐ Yes, it is an audit that only requires minimal approvals.
- ☐ Yes, and I have all necessary approvals.
- ☐ Yes, but I don't yet have all necessary approvals.

What information about participants or data subjects will you collect and/or use?

Anonymised channels of YouTube users and video titles.

What safeguards do you have in place to ensure you will only use the absolute minimum of personal data required, anonymise personal data where possible and pseudonymise where anonymisation is not possible?

Pre-analysis YouTube API anonymisation according to the official YouTube ToS and User Privacy agreements.

How will you store data securely?

On a protected hard drive with secure access that is password protected.

Risk of participant identification

Please identify and list all risks to the privacy of research participants, consider how likely it is that these risks will manifest, and what the harm to participants could be if the risks manifest. Consult with your collaborators if necessary. The statements below represent possible causes. If you are not sure about the risks, start your research by [consulting the University's guidance on handling sensitive data](#).

	Likelihood of Risk			Severity of Harm		
	Remote	Possible	Probable	Minimal	Significant	Severe
Data linkage	☐	☒	☐	☒	☐	☐
Low participant numbers	☒	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Geographical location	☒	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Transfer of data	☒	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Access of data	☒	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐
Other (please explain)	☒	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
Stale Data						

You are nearly done, make sure to click next below!

Your reference number is **239589**. Please mention this in any correspondence with **ethics-query@inf.ed.ac.uk**. We will do our best to send you feedback within 10 working days. Please do not start data collection or analysis before we have confirmed successful self-certification. Your response has been recorded by the Qualtrics system and in the Ethics Committee RT system.

Here is a list of the documents you have to send to **ethics-query@inf.ed.ac.uk**, Subject: "*Supporting documents for application 239589*". Tick them off to tell us that you have prepared them. Even if no supporting documents are listed on this page, we still strongly encourage you to send us your [**data management plan**](#). Templates for participant information sheets and consent forms can be found on the [**Informatics Hub**](#).

☒ **Participant Information Sheet/Consent Form**

Any other ethics-related issues or aspects you would like to state? (Optional)

I beleive my supervisor has already gained consent for using this dataset on research they are conducting on the YouNiverse Dataset related to the research I am conducting, I just wanted to double check that this is all good.

Please contact the Ethics Committee at **inf-ethics@inf.ed.ac.uk** if you have further questions unrelated to your ethics application.